

allure.

According to the locals, Barbados is the finest island in the Caribbean — a claim that sparks lively debate among residents of Trinidad, St. Lucia, and beyond. The tiny island, 21 miles long and 15 miles wide, is abuzz as English fans pour into the Kensington Oval for a pivotal Group B showdown against their arch-rival, Australia. The stands are a vibrant sea of red, white, and blue. The venue is just a few typos away from being the Kennington Oval!

The Diary has often observed that the knowledge of taxi drivers offers a unique glimpse into a region's passion for cricket, particularly in the sport's traditional strongholds. "That passion is still there," remarks Marc St. John, a cab driver in Bridgetown. "But I think the people here struggle to accept this West Indies team."

As the conversation wore on, Marc's tone grew increasingly despondent, though he hadn't lost all hope. "I don't think the glory days of Holding, Marshall, and Richards are coming back... naah, brother, that's not happening," he lamented. "But I feel we get so caught up in our past that we fail to appreciate the current side for its title wins."

A glowing example of Barbados' enduring love affair with cricket is the 5-dollar note issued by the Central Bank of Barbados in 2018. The obverse of the green note features the Barbadian coat of arms, a map of Barbados, and a portrait of the legendary cricketer Frank Worrell. On the reverse, the note depicts the 3Ws (Frank Worrell, Everton Weekes, and Clyde Walcott) and the Oval cricket facility located at the University of the West Indies, Cave Hill Campus.

Over at the Oval, the Diary encounters John, a local keymaker, and inquires about his allegiance. His response is surprising. He hopes England or India makes it to the finals, not the West Indies. "If we

reach the final, it's just going to be home fans. We need visitors to kick up the business. It's been tough after COVID-19," he explains.

One can't help but feel the weight of those words. The heart of Caribbean cricket, once beating with unyielding pride, now grapples with the harsh realities of modern economics. Meanwhile, Australia delivered a clinical performance on the field, with its trio of fast bowlers and leg-spinner Adam Zampa dismantling England and spoiling the homecoming of local hero Jofra Archer.

Next stop? The kingdom of the cricketing prince, Brian Charles Lara. The Diary arrives at Piarco International Airport in Trinidad after a swift hour-long flight from Barbados, greeted by a persistent drizzle and cool winds — a refreshing reprieve from the relentless heat and humidity endured back home over the past four months.

It is the start of the rainy season in the Caribbean and the weather department issued thunderstorm warnings ahead of what was West Indies' first men's World Cup match at the Brian Lara Stadium in Trinidad. But luckily, the rain clouds steered clear and the atmosphere remained festive as, in front of a packed house, the West Indies qualified for Super



Note-worthy: The 5-dollar note issued by the Central Bank of Barbados in 2018 features a map of the island, its coat of arms, and a portrait of the legendary cricketer Frank Worrell. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Renewed hope: Fans in the Caribbean truly believe that this is the year their team wins a record third T20 World Cup title. GETTY IMAGES